

hypothesis

corDECT

▲ What is it?

Wireless Local Loop (WLL) technology developed by IIT, Madras and Midas Communication Technologies, Chennai that promises to bring very affordable telephone and Internet access. The small size of a corDECT box makes it easy to install in homes and contains ports for a telephone and PC.

▲ What's so special?

corDECT does not require standard cabling as used in conventional telephone systems. Instead, it uses wireless technologies which saves substantial costs in cabling and installation. A single corDECT system can provide a maximum bandwidth of 70 kbps per household which is shared between voice and data.

▲ Where can it be useful?

With the corDECT technology, the cost of bringing telephone access to villages is significantly less. Together with access to telephones, this system also allows villagers access to the Internet with similar ease and low cost.

SNAPSHOT 76 per cent

is the viewership for television

while the Internet, despite being a gargantuan source of information, enjoys a viewership of just 8 per cent

Source: www.nielsen-netratings.com

3D games: now for PDAs

Gaming addicts will no longer feel the fright of withdrawal symptoms in leaving their PCs and consoles at home. Now they can take their fix with them. Finnish gaming company Fathammer has developed a 3D gaming engine called X-Forge, for Pocket PC based handhelds. Obviously, the first question that comes to mind is how 3D graphics can be achieved in



the first place with the limited resources in a handheld? Without a doubt, the tech demos have been very impressive so far with catchy music and vivid 3D imagery. But what's more important is that X-Forge also works with Linux and Symbian OS, giving game makers a lot of flexibility in making use of this graphical breakthrough in handheld computers.

April fools with VoIP

It's time to rejoice for fans of VoIP. The current block on long distance calls over the Net is finally nearing its end. Come April 1, 2002, VSNL will finally lift the ban on VoIP. This is the announcement made by India's IT minister, Pramod Mahajan.

Once it arrives, however, and knowing the government's wonderful sense of sniffing out an opportunity, don't be surprised if VoIP comes at a price. Nonetheless, it should be much cheaper than making an ISD call to the US.

Hotmail to trim excess flab

With many e-mail services moving towards a subscription, it is nice to know Hotmail is still free. But attention Hotmail users! Check your Hotmail e-mail at least once every 30 days or you're going to lose it! Microsoft threw up this announcement to users of



Hotmail's free e-mail service in a move to hopefully convince its users to shift over to their pay-for-premium service. Though the pay service will not expire after a period of inactivity, attracting long-time users of free e-mail will be a very difficult task.

Benchmarking the benchmark

A huge controversy has been raging over the new drivers that ATi released recently. We all have heard about performance boosts from the new detonator XP but this one comes from ATi. It seems like these have been specifically written with *Quake III: Arena* in mind and there are *Quake III* specific instructions in the Windows 2000 Radeon 8500 drivers version 5.13.01.3276. With this new driver set people have reported to have found up to 20 per cent increase in frame rate in *Quake III*. Effectively, with this driver you can safely say that the Radeon 8500 will beat the nVidia Geforce 3 Ti500 hands down.

Now whether or not this driver set is cheating the 'benchmark' is yet to be seen and understood. Nevertheless, it is effectively a massive increase and can only be achieved by some major tweaking. Now to be very frank, the ATi team is not known to churn out some amazing drivers and are at most times blamed for botched up driver releases.

Also, you really can't judge quality in a fast moving demo and only after a close scrutiny of image quality in actual gameplay can one come to a conclusion. So whether or not the ATi driver is compromising on quality (which is holy to *Quake III* fanatics) is yet to be seen. Also consider the fact that *Quake III* is without doubt the most widely used gaming benchmark. It's almost the 'holy benchmark'; if you win here, you win everywhere!